comparing the situation facing the Congress Party to the one the Guomindang had faced in China before they fell to the communists.[125]

The security realm did not seem any more promising between June 1964 and April 1965. The China threat showed no sign of dissipating.[126] China conducted its first nuclear test in October 1964, which Shastri told Zhou was a "retrograde and deplorable" step.[127] It led to calls in India for a nuclear weapons program.[128] An Indian attempt to turn the test against China in the developing world went nowhere; neither did Shastri's proposal for the nonaligned states to act together to stop the Chinese nuclear program.[129]

The nonaligned states indeed seemed to admire the Chinese achievement and see the Chinese path as more attractive.[130] And Beijing continued its propaganda drive to convince them the Indian path was inferior. It played up India's military defeat and the foreign assistance it was receiving to keep it afloat. Furthermore, China took the lead in organizing a second Afro-Asian conference and successfully blocked Indian attempts to invite the Soviet Union to the conference. Contemporary political observer Michael Brecher called this the period of India's "dwarfing by China."[131]

To make matters worse, Shastri and Chavan believed China and Pakistan were growing even closer.[132] China offered Pakistan loans as well as support on the Kashmir issue. The two countries announced that they had completed the boundary demarcation, which Delhi protested as "illegal and invalid."[133] A number of senior Chinese and Pakistani political and military leaders exchanged visits, capped off by visits by Ayub to China and Zhou to Pakistan in spring 1965. US officials noted that Ayub's visit "represent[ed] significant consolidation of [the] Pak-ChiCom relationship."[134] High-level Chinese leaders visited Afghanistan and Nepal, offering aid and support to these countries in India's neighborhood.[135] China furthermore communicated directly with the Sikkimese king, which Delhi saw as calling into question its special relationship with Sikkim.[136]

Indian policymakers also feared Chinese intervention in what India considered internal issues. This concern was only exacerbated by indications from the US that, after the Sino-Soviet split, Beijing was taking more aggressive stances to compete with Moscow and was likely to focus on subversion.[137] Thus Indian officials were angered when, in the midst of an unfurling India-Pakistan crisis, Zhou met with Kashmiri leader Sheikh